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Deepti Sharma likes being feared. She relishes the fact that opponents worry when the ball is handed to her, wary not only of her smart off-spin but also of a potential non-striker run-out. She knows the rules of the game and lords over her opponents. A gun fielding arm is a bonus.

Over 11 years of international cricket, the now 28-year-old has amassed an enviable haul of accolades and records. But nothing, not yet at least, compares to her long-awaited triumph in the 2025 Women's ODI World Cup, where she finished as the Player of the Tournament.

It is clichéd to say the weeks since have been a blur for the victorious side, yet that is the reality Deepti is living. She has been home for barely a few days, pulled in every direction for felicitations, ad shoots, bureaucratic meetings, and endorsement deals.

"I've barely had time to process the win. Anyone and everyone is flocking home to meet me, and meetings have come up one after another," she tells *Sportstar* in the middle of an ad shoot that has brought her to Mumbai.

This isn't a new experience for the southpaw. A runner-up finish in the 2017 World Cup brought her exploits to enough people for the Sharma family to struggle for privacy in their home in Agra.

"People were sad we didn't win, but were very happy with how far we went. There was a time when I couldn't step out of the home without someone coming up to me for photographs or autographs for some time," she recalls.

This was a massive change from when

neighbours and acquaintances once tried their best to dissuade her parents from considering cricket as a path for their daughter.

"No one ever told me this directly, but many people told my parents that cricket *ladkiyon ka khel nahin hai* (cricket is not a sport for women). They suggested my mom and dad should focus on educating me and getting me married. But my parents never bothered to lend an ear to anything like this. So many of those people are now patting my back and welcoming me after a World Cup win. Things have certainly changed a lot," she says with a big smile.

Adding to the satisfaction is the fact that the road leading to her residence is now named after her, *Arjuna Awardee Cricketer Deepti Sharma Marg*.

Years ago, on this very lane, Deepti's cricketing dreams slowly began sprouting wings.

"When I was in school, there were a couple of friends I used to play gully cricket with. Whenever we got a break, we used to play. On Sundays as well. I would call, and we would all head out to play. It's something I still remember very clearly."

Life took them all in different directions, but many of them were in attendance watching as a 10-kilometre-long roadshow welcomed their old buddy back to the historic city, wishing that they, too, had stuck with something that once seemed to have no future.

Imposter to superstar

It helped that her brother Sumit, who would eventually become the pillar supporting her career, also pursued cricket, even playing the C. K. Nayudu Trophy before moving on to a different profession. He would eventually quit

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